



SQUEEZING IN FORTY WINKS AT 30,000 FT IN BETWEEN HALF-A-DOZEN DAILY CAMPAIGN MEETINGS. SEATED BEHIND ADVANI IS AIDE DEEPAK CHOPRA.

from the backyard of mythology to the frontline of technology at the click of a mouse. "You become old when you cease to learn new things in life," he tells you.

The youthfulness that has already declared independence from his biological age is most visible when he is out there in the battlefield. There are no signs of fatigue as he moves from jet to helicopter to the stage in saffron. Still, Advani on the stump is a great explainer, an avuncular analyst who is least interested in entertaining the crowd with his Ciceronian flourish, like a Vajpayee or a Narendra Modi. In places like Simdega, Lohardagga and Dhanbad in Jharkhand, he is not a performing demagogue but an earnest preacher who can't afford to fly away from the shirtless without making them wiser. As the wretched of this arid land snack on wild berries, the man who wants to be their next prime minister tells them how he's going to make the 21st Century the Indian century. He promises them the marvel of computer education; he tells

them the horrors of an India ruled by a Congress-led government, horrors stretching from farmers' suicide to terrorist attacks to inflation to votebank politics whose first casualty is national security. He is particularly concerned about the girl child: "When a girl is born, it should not be a cause for worry. She is Saraswati. She should be given a proper education." Prime Minister Advani would see that she got one. If the BJP wins, he tells

them, India wins. He admits that he cannot win with the force of his words alone. He is no soundbite savant. "I'm not a great public speaker like Vajpayee," he tells you once he is back in the Bell 412 copter, which will take him to the next rally. "He could play with words. That is why I wanted to take care of the organisation." Then, as an aside, he laments, "The Congress has no campaign. It has got a leader who doesn't like people."

So you are with a leader who believes that he has to win India through the force of his conviction as a moderniser and a

HIS campaign is sustained by an idea called Advani and is managed by his favourite few who continue to defy organisational hierarchy.

